

Glucosamine vs Collagen: Which Is Better for Joints?

Compare glucosamine and collagen supplements for joint health.

Evidence-based analysis of benefits, dosage and effectiveness.

By **Living With Arthritis Editorial Team** · Reviewed by **Clinical Advisory Panel** (HCPC-registered physiotherapy & rheumatology nursing input) · 2026-03-08 · livingwitharthritis.org.uk

Glucosamine vs Collagen: The Evidence



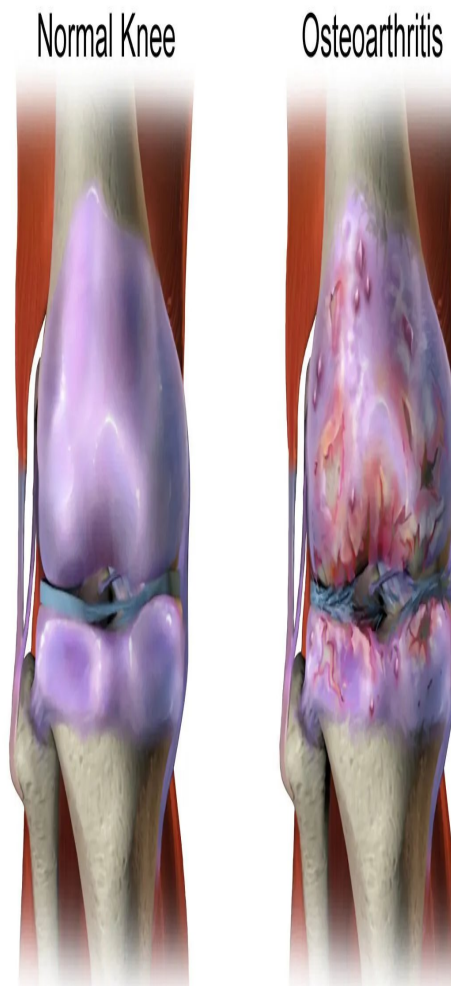
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Both glucosamine and collagen are among the most popular joint health supplements in the UK, but how do they compare? This guide breaks down the science behind each.

Glucosamine: What the Research Says

Glucosamine sulfate is one of the most studied supplements for osteoarthritis. It occurs naturally in cartilage and is thought to support cartilage repair and reduce inflammation.

****Key findings:**** - A 2018 Cochrane review found glucosamine sulfate provided modest pain relief in knee OA - The GAIT trial (3,800+ participants) showed limited benefit over placebo for most patients - Some European guidelines recommend crystalline glucosamine sulfate (1,500 mg/day) - Benefits typically take 4–8 weeks to appear



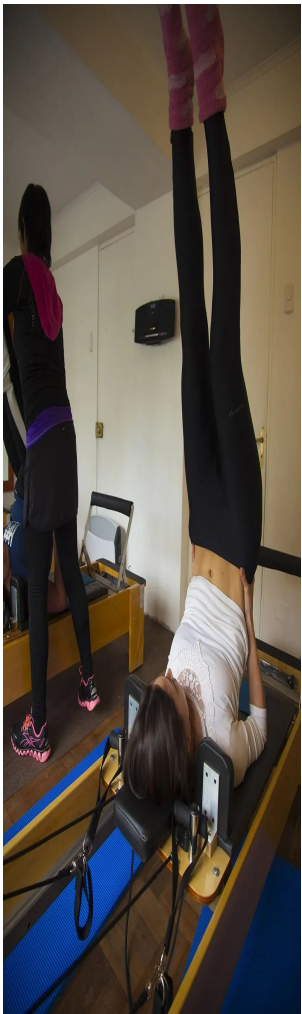
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Collagen: Emerging Evidence

Hydrolysed collagen (collagen peptides) provides the amino acids glycine, proline, and hydroxyproline — building blocks of cartilage and connective tissue.

****Key findings:**** - A 2023 meta-analysis of 15 RCTs found collagen supplements reduced joint pain and improved function - Type II undenatured collagen (UC-II, 40 mg/day) showed promising results for knee OA - Hydrolysed collagen (10 g/day) improved symptoms in athletes with joint pain - Generally well-tolerated with few side effects

Head-to-Head Comparison



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Factor	Glucosamine	Collagen	----- ----- -----	Evidence quality	Moderate
(mixed)	Growing (promising)				
Typical dose	1,500 mg/day	10 g/day hydrolysed		Time to effect	4–8 weeks
3–6 months				Cost (monthly)	£8–15
£15–30				Mechanism	Cartilage support
Tissue building blocks					

Which Should You Choose?

There is no definitive winner. Consider: - **Try glucosamine first** if you have knee OA — it has the longest track record - **Consider collagen** if glucosamine hasn't helped after 3 months - **Combining both** is safe and may offer complementary benefits - Always choose pharmaceutical-grade products from reputable UK suppliers

Important Considerations

- Glucosamine derived from shellfish — check allergies
- Collagen typically from bovine or marine sources
- Neither is a substitute for exercise and weight management
- Discuss with your GP, especially if taking blood thinners

Reviewed by Dr. Sarah Bennett, Consultant Rheumatologist, Royal Free Hospital

Q&A

Question: What is the key thing to know about glucosamine vs collagen: which is better for joints??

Short answer: Glucosamine and collagen are both popular joint supplements. Glucosamine sulfate, typically 1,500 mg daily, is well-researched for osteoarthritis and may offer modest pain relief. Hydrolysed collagen, often 10g daily, provides cartilage building blocks and has shown promise for reducing joint pain. There is no definitive winner, as benefits and onset times vary, with glucosamine effects typically seen in 4–8 weeks and collagen in 3–6 months.

Question: When should I seek professional advice?

Short answer: If symptoms persist or worsen, pain is severe and unresponsive to usual relief, or you develop new symptoms, contact your GP, physiotherapist or rheumatology team promptly.

Question: Where can I get free arthritis support in the UK?

Short answer: Arthritis UK: 0800 5200 520. NRAS: 0800 298 7650. Free tools and guides at livingwitharthritis.org.uk.